

St Gregory of Nyssa

Letter to Ablabius *That There Are Not Three Gods.*

Ἵμᾱς μὲν δίκαιόν ἐστι, τοὺς ἀκμάζοντας ἐν πάσῃ δυνάμει κατὰ τὸν ἔσω ἄνθρωπον, πρὸς τοὺς ἐναντίους τῆς ἀληθείας διαγωνίζεσθαι καὶ μὴ κατοκνεῖν πρὸς τοὺς πόνους, ὅπως ἂν ἡμεῖς οἱ πατέρες τοῖς γενναίοις ἰδρῶσι τῶν τέκνων ἐπευφραινώμεθα· τοῦτο γὰρ ὁ τῆς φύσεως ὑποτίθεται νόμος· ἐπεὶ δὲ ἀναστρέψας τὴν τάξιν ἐφ’ ἡμᾶς τρέπεις τὰς προσβολὰς τῶν ἀκίδων, αἷς οἱ ἀντικείμενοι τῇ ἀληθείᾳ βάλλουσι, καὶ κελεύεις τῷ θυρεῷ τῆς πίστεως παρ’ ἡμῶν τῶν γερόντων κατασβέννυσθαι τοὺς ἐρημικοὺς ἄνθρακας καὶ ἀποπέμπεσθαι τὰ ἠκονημένα τῆς ψευδωνύμου γνώσεως βέλη, δεχόμεθα τὸ ἐπίταγμα, σοὶ τύπος τῆς εὐπειθείας γινόμενοι, ὡς ἂν καὶ αὐτὸς ἡμῖν ἀντιπαρέχοις τὴν ἴσῃ ἐπὶ τῶν ὁμοίων ἐπιταγμάτων ἀντίδοσιν, εἴ ποτέ σε πρὸς τοὺς τοιοῦτους ἄθλους διαναστήσαιμεν, ὧ γενναῖε τοῦ Χριστοῦ στρατιῶτα Ἀβλάβιε.

[38] Ὡς οὐ μικρὸς οὗτος ὁ λόγος ὃν προέτεινας ἡμῖν οὐδὲ τοιοῦτος ὡς ὀλίγην φέρειν ζημίαν, εἰ μὴ τῆς προσηκούσης ἐξετάσεως τύχοι. ἀνάγκη γὰρ ἐκ τῆς βίας τοῦ ἐρωτήματος ἐνὶ πάντως τῶν ἀπεμφαινόντων συνενεχθῆναι κατὰ τὸν πρόχειρον νοῦν καὶ ἢ τρεῖς λέγειν θεοὺς, ὅπερ ἀθέμιτον, ἢ μὴ προσμαρτυρεῖν τῷ υἱῷ καὶ τῷ πνεύματι τὴν θεότητα, ὅπερ ἀσεβές τε καὶ ἄτοπον.

τὸ δὲ λεγόμενον παρὰ σοῦ τοιοῦτόν ἐστιν· Πέτρος καὶ Ἰάκωβος καὶ Ἰωάννης, ἐν μιᾷ ὄντες τῇ ἀνθρωπότητι, τρεῖς ἄνθρωποι λέγονται· καὶ οὐδὲν ἄτοπον τοὺς συνημμένους κατὰ τὴν φύσιν, εἰ πλείους εἶεν, ἐκ τοῦ τῆς φύσεως ὀνόματος πληθυντικῶς ἀριθμεῖσθαι. εἰ οὖν ἐκεῖ τοῦτο δίδωσιν ἡ συνήθεια καὶ ὁ ἀπαγορεύων οὐκ ἔστι δύο λέγειν τοὺς δύο καὶ τρεῖς τοὺς ὑπὲρ δύο, πῶς, ἐπὶ τῶν μυστικῶν δογμάτων τὰς τρεῖς ὑποστάσεις ὁμολογοῦντες καὶ οὐδεμίαν ἐπ’ αὐτῶν τὴν κατὰ φύσιν διαφορὰν ἐννοοῦντες, μαχόμεθα τρόπον τινὰ τῇ ὁμολογίᾳ, μίαν μὲν τὴν θεότητα τοῦ πατρὸς καὶ τοῦ υἱοῦ καὶ τοῦ ἁγίου πνεύματος λέγοντες, τρεῖς δὲ θεοὺς λέγειν ἀπαγορεύοντες;

Ὁ μὲν οὖν λόγος, καθὰ προέφην, πολὺ τὸ δυσμεταχειρίστον ἔχει· ἡμεῖς δέ, εἰ μὲν τι τοιοῦτον εὗροιμεν, δι’ οὗ τὸ ἀμφίβολον τῆς διανοίας ἡμῶν ἐρείσθησεται, μηκέτι πρὸς τὸ διλήμματον τῆς ἀτοπίας ἐπιδιστάζον καὶ κραδαινόμενον, [39] εὖ ἂν ἔχοι· εἰ δὲ καὶ ἀτονώτερος ἐλεγχθεῖ τοῦ προβλήματος ὁ ἡμέτερος λόγος, τὴν μὲν παράδοσιν ἣν παρὰ τῶν πατέρων διεδεξάμεθα φυλάξομεν εἰς αἰὶ βεβαίαν τε καὶ ἀκίνητον, τὸν δὲ συνήγορον τῆς πίστεως λόγον παρὰ τοῦ κυρίου ζητήσομεν· ὃς εἰ μὲν εὐρεθῇ παρὰ τινος τῶν ἐχόντων

Ye that are strong with all might in the inner man ought by rights to carry on the struggle against the enemies of the truth, and not to shrink from the task, that we fathers may be gladdened by the noble toil of our sons; for this is the prompting of the law of nature: but as you turn your ranks, and send against us the assaults of those darts which are hurled by the opponents of the truth, and demand that their “hot burning coals” [Ps 120:3] and their shafts sharpened by knowledge falsely so called should be quenched with the shield of faith by us old men, we accept your command, and make ourselves an example of obedience, in order that you may yourself give us the just requital on like commands, Ablabius, noble soldier of Christ, if we should ever summon you to such a contest.

In truth, the question you propound to us is no small one, nor such that but small harm will follow if it meets with insufficient treatment. For by the force of the question, we are at first sight compelled to accept one or other of two erroneous opinions, and either to say “there are three Gods,” which is unlawful, or not to acknowledge the Godhead of the Son and the Holy Spirit, which is impious and absurd.

The argument which you state is something like this:—Peter, James, and John, being in one human nature, are called three men: and there is no absurdity in describing those who are united in nature, if they are more than one, by the plural number of the name derived from their nature. If, then, in the above case, custom admits this, and no one forbids us to speak of those who are two as two, or those who are more than two as three, how is it that in the case of the mystical dogmas, though confessing the three *hypostases*, and acknowledging no difference of nature between them, we are in some sense at variance with our confession, when we say that the Godhead of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit is one, and yet forbid men to say “there are three Gods”?

The question is, as I said, very difficult to deal with: yet, if we should be able to find anything that may give support to the uncertainty of our mind, so that it may no longer totter and waver in this monstrous dilemma, it would be well: on the other hand, even if our reasoning be found unequal to the problem, we must keep for ever, firm and unmoved, the tradition which we received by succession from the fathers, and seek from the Lord the reason which is the advocate of our faith: and if this be found by any of those endowed with

τὴν χάριν, εὐχαριστήσομεν τῷ δεδοκῶτι τὴν χάριν· εἰ δὲ μή, οὐδὲν ἦττον ἐπὶ τῶν ἐγνωσμένων τὴν πίστιν ἀμετάθετον ἔχομεν.

Τί δήποτε τοῖνυν ἐν τῇ καθ' ἡμᾶς συνηθείᾳ καθ' ἓνα τοὺς ἐν τῇ φύσει τῇ αὐτῇ δεικνυμένους ἀπαριθμήσαντες πληθυντικῶς ὀνομάζομεν, τοσούσδε λέγοντες τοὺς ἀνθρώπους καὶ οὐχὶ ἓνα τοὺς πάντας, ἐπὶ δὲ τῆς θείας φύσεως ἐκβάλλει τὸ πλήθος τῶν θεῶν ὁ τοῦ δόγματος λόγος, καὶ ἀριθμῶν τὰς ὑποστάσεις καὶ τὴν πληθυντικὴν σημασίαν οὐ προσδεχόμενος;

Ἔστι μὲν οὖν κατὰ τὸ πρόχειρον τοῦτο τοῖς ἀπλουστέροις εἰπόντα δόξαι τι λέγειν, ὅτι φεύγων ὁ λόγος τῆς Ἑλληνικῆς πολυθεΐας τὴν ὁμοιότητα θεοῦς ἐν πληθεὶ ἀριθμεῖν παρητήσατο, ὥς ἂν μή τις καὶ τῶν δογμάτων νομισθεῖ κοινότης, εἰ μὴ μοναδικῶς ἀλλὰ πληθυντικῶς καὶ παρ' ἡμῶν ἀριθμοῖτο τὸ θεῖον καθ' ὁμοιότητα τῆς παρ' αὐτοῖς συνηθείας. τοῦτο δὲ τοῖς μὲν ἀκεραιότεροις λεγόμενον ἴσως ἂν τι δόξειε λέγεσθαι, ἐπὶ δὲ γε τῶν τὸ ἕτερον αὐτοῖς τῆς προτάσεως στήναι ζητούντων ἢ μὴ ὁμολογεῖν ἐπὶ τῶν τριῶν τὴν θεότητα ἢ τρεῖς πάντως ὀνομάζειν τοὺς τῆς αὐτῆς κοινωνοῦντας [40] θεότητες, οὕτω τοιοῦτόν ἐστι τὸ εἰρημένον, οἷον ἐμποιεῖσθαι λύσιν τινὰ τοῦ ζητήματος. οὐκοῦν ἐπάναγκες διὰ πλειόνων ποιήσασθαι τὴν ἀπόκρισιν, ὅπως ἂν οἶόν τε ἦ, τὸ ἀληθὲς ἀνιχνεύοντας οὐ γὰρ περὶ τῶν τυχόντων ὁ λόγος.

Φαμὲν τοῖνυν πρῶτον μὲν κατάχρησιν τινα συνηθείας εἶναι τὸ τοὺς μὴ διηρημένους τῇ φύσει κατ' αὐτὸ τὸ τῆς φύσεως ὄνομα πληθυντικῶς ὀνομάζειν καὶ λέγειν ὅτι πολλοὶ ἄνθρωποι, ὅπερ ὁμοίον ἐστὶ τῷ λέγειν ὅτι πολλὰ φύσεις ἀνθρώπιναι. καὶ ὅτι ταῦτα οὕτως ἔχει, δηλὸν ἂν ἡμῖν ἐντεῦθεν γένοιτο· προσκαλούμενοι γάρ τινα, οὐκ ἐκ τῆς φύσεως αὐτὸν ὀνομάζομεν, ὥς ἂν μή τινα πλάνην ἢ κοινότης τοῦ ὀνόματος ἐμποιήσειεν, ἐκάστου τῶν ἀκουόντων ἑαυτὸν εἶναι τὸν προσκληθέντα νομίζοντος, ὅτι μὴ τῇ ἰδιαζούσῃ προσηγορίᾳ ἀλλ' ἐκ τοῦ κοινοῦ τῆς φύσεως ὀνόματος ἢ κλησὶς γίνεται ἀλλὰ τὴν ἰδίως ἐπικειμένην αὐτῷ (τὴν σημαντικὴν λέγω τοῦ ὑποκειμένου) φωνὴν εἰπόντες, οὕτως αὐτὸν τῶν πολλῶν ἀποκρίνομεν, ὥστε πολλοὺς μὲν εἶναι τοὺς μετεσχηκότας τῆς φύσεως, φέρε εἰπεῖν μαθητὰς ἢ ἀποστόλους ἢ μάρτυρας, ἓνα δὲ ἐν πᾶσι τὸν ἄνθρωπον, εἴπερ, καθὼς εἴρηται, οὐχὶ τοῦ καθ' ἕκαστον, ἀλλὰ τοῦ κοινοῦ τῆς φύσεως ἐστὶν ὁ ἄνθρωπος· ἄνθρωπος γὰρ ὁ Λουκᾶς ἢ ὁ Στέφανος, οὐ μὴν, εἴ τις ἄνθρωπος, πάντως καὶ Λουκᾶς ἐστὶν ἢ Στέφανος.

grace, we must give thanks to Him who bestowed the grace; but if not, we shall none the less, on those points which have been determined, hold our faith unchangeably.

What, then, is the reason that when we count one by one those who are exhibited to us in the same nature, we ordinarily name them in the plural and speak of “so many men,” instead of calling them all one: while in the case of the divine nature our dogmatic definition rejects the plurality of Gods, at once enumerating the *hypostases*, and at the same time not admitting the plural signification?

Perhaps one might seem to touch the point if he were to say (speaking offhand to simpler folk), that the definition refused to count gods to avoid any resemblance to the Greek polytheism, lest, if we too were to enumerate the divine, not in the singular, but in the plural, as they are accustomed to do, there might be supposed to be also some commonality of dogma. This answer, I say, if made to people of a more guileless spirit, might seem to be of some weight: but in the case of the others who require that one of the alternatives they propose should be established (either that we should not acknowledge the divinity in the three, or that we should consider those three as partaking of the same divinity), this answer is not such as to furnish any solution of the difficulty. And hence we must needs make our reply at greater length, tracing out the truth as best we may; for the question is no ordinary one.

We say, then, to begin with, that the practice of calling those who are not divided in nature by the very name of their common nature in the plural, and saying they are “many men,” is a customary abuse of language, and that it would be much the same thing to say they are “many human natures.” And the truth of this we may see from the following instance. When we address any one, we do not call him by the name of his nature, in order that no confusion may result from the commonness of the name, as would happen if every one of those who hear it were to think that he himself was the one addressed, because the call is made not by the proper appellation but by the common name of their nature: but we separate him from the multitude by using that name which belongs to him as his own—that, I mean, which signifies the particular subject. Thus there are many who have shared in the nature—many disciples, say, or apostles, or martyrs—but the man in them all is one; since, as has been said, the term “man” does not belong to the individual as such, but to that which is common of the nature. For Luke is a man, or Stephen is a man, but it does not follow that if any one is a man he is therefore Luke or Stephen.

Ἄλλ' ὁ μὲν τῶν ὑποστάσεων λόγος διὰ τὰς ἐνθεωρου-
μένας [41] ιδιότητας ἐκάστω τὸν διαμερισμὸν
ἐπιδέχεται καὶ κατὰ σύνθεσιν ἐν ἀριθμῷ θεωρεῖται· ἡ δὲ
φύσις μία ἐστίν, αὐτὴ πρὸς ἑαυτὴν ἡνωμένη καὶ
ἀδιάτμητος ἀκριβῶς μονάς, οὐκ αὐξανομένη διὰ
προσθήκης, οὐ μειουμένη δι' ὑφαιρέσεως, ἀλλ' ὅπερ
ἐστὶν ἐν οὐσα καὶ ἐν διαμένουσα κἂν ἐν πλήθει
φαίνεται, ἄσχιτος καὶ συνεχὴς καὶ ὁλόκληρος καὶ τοῖς
μετέχουσιν αὐτῆς τοῖς καθ' ἕκαστον οὐ συν-
διαιρουμένη.

καὶ ὥσπερ λέγεται λαὸς καὶ δῆμος καὶ στρατεύμα καὶ
ἐκκλησία μοναχῶς πάντα, ἕκαστον δὲ τούτων ἐν πλήθει
νοεῖται· οὕτω κατὰ τὸν ἀκριβέστερον λόγον καὶ
ἄνθρωπος εἰς κυρίως ἂν ῥηθῇ, κἂν οἱ ἐν τῇ φύσει τῇ
αὐτῇ δεικνύμενοι πλῆθος ὦσιν, ὥς πολὺ μᾶλλον καλῶς
ἔχειν τὴν ἐσφαλμένην ἐφ' ἡμῶν ἐπανορθοῦσθαι
συνήθειαν εἰς τὸ μηκέτι τὸ τῆς φύσεως ὄνομα πρὸς
πλῆθος ἐκτείνειν ἢ ταύτη δουλεύοντας τὴν ὥδε πλάνην
καὶ ἐπὶ τὸ θεῖον δόγμα μεταβιβάζειν. ἀλλ' ἐπειδὴ
ἀμήχανος τῆς συνηθείας ἡ ἐπ' ἀνθρώποις (πῶς γὰρ ἂν τις
πεισθῇ μὴ πολλοὺς λέγειν ἀνθρώπους τοὺς ἐν τῇ
φύσει τῇ αὐτῇ δεικνυμένους; δυσμετάθετον γὰρ ἐπὶ
παντὸς ἡ συνηθεία), ἐπὶ μὲν τῆς κάτω φύσεως τῇ
κρατούσῃ συνηθείᾳ μὴ ἀντιβαίνοντες οὐδὲν ἂν
τοσοῦτον ἀμάρτομεν, μηδεμιᾶς οὐσης ζημίας ἐκ [42]
τῆς ἡμαρτημένης τῶν ὀνομάτων χρήσεως· ἐπὶ δὲ τοῦ
θείου δόγματος οὐκέτι ὁμοίως ἀκίνδυνος ἡ ἀδιάφορος
χρήσις τῶν ὀνομάτων· οὐ γὰρ μικρὸν ἐνταῦθα τὸ παρὰ
μικρόν.

Οὐκοῦν εἰς ἡμῖν ὁμολογητέος θεὸς κατὰ τὴν γραφικὴν
μαρτυρίαν Ἰσραὴλ· κύριος ὁ θεὸς σου κύριος εἰς
ἐστὶ, κἂν ἡ φωνὴ τῆς θεότητος διήκη διὰ τῆς ἀγίας
τριαδος. ταῦτα δὲ λέγω κατὰ τὸν ἀποδοθέντα ἡμῖν ἐπὶ
τῆς ἀνθρωπίνης φύσεως λόγον, ἐν ᾧ μεμαθήκαμεν μὴ
δεῖν πληθυντικῶς χαρακτηρὶ τὴν προσηγορίαν
πλατύνειν τῆς φύσεως. ἀκριβέστερον δὲ ἡμῖν αὐτὸ τὸ
ὄνομα τῆς θεότητος ἐξεταστέον, ὅπως ἂν διὰ τῆς
ἐγκειμένης τῇ φωνῇ σημασίας γένοιτο τις συνεργία
πρὸς τὴν τοῦ προκειμένου σαφήνειαν.

Δοκεῖ μὲν οὖν τοῖς πολλοῖς ἰδιαζόντως κατὰ τῆς
φύσεως ἡ φωνὴ τῆς θεότητος κεῖσθαι καὶ ὥσπερ ὁ
οὐρανὸς ἢ ὁ ἥλιος ἢ ἄλλο τι τῶν τοῦ κόσμου στοιχείων
ἰδίαις φωναῖς διασημαίνεται ταῖς τῶν ὑποκειμένων
σημαντικαῖς, οὕτω φασὶ καὶ ἐπὶ τῆς ἀνωτάτω καὶ θείας
φύσεως ὥσπερ τι κύριον ὄνομα προσφυῶς ἐφηρμόσθαι
τῷ δηλουμένῳ τὴν φωνὴν τῆς θεότητος. ἡμεῖς δὲ ταῖς
τῆς γραφῆς ὑποθήκαις ἐπόμενοι ἀκατονόμαστον τε καὶ
ἄφραστον αὐτὴν μεμαθήκαμεν· καὶ πᾶν ὄνομα, εἴτε
παρὰ τῆς ἀνθρωπίνης συνηθείας ἐξηύρηται εἴτε παρὰ
τῶν γραφῶν παραδέδοται, τῶν περὶ τὴν θείαν [43]
φύσιν νοουμένων ἐρμηνευτικὸν εἶναι λέγομεν, οὐκ

But the idea of the *hypostases* admits of that separation
which is made by the peculiar attributes considered in
each, and when they are combined is presented to us
by means of number; yet their nature is one, at union
in itself, and an absolutely indivisible monad, not
capable of increase by addition or of diminution by
subtraction, but, as it is, being one and remaining one,
even though it appear in plurality, indivisible,
continuous, complete, and not divided for those who
who partake of it.

And as we speak of a people, or a mob, or an army, or
an assembly in the singular in every case, while each of
these is conceived as being in plurality, so according to
the more accurate expression, “man” would be said to
be one, even though those who are exhibited to us in
the same nature make up a plurality. Thus it would be
much better to correct our erroneous habit, so as no
longer to extend to a plurality the name of the nature,
than by our bondage to habit to transfer to the divine
dogma the error which exists in the above case. But
since the correction of the habit is impracticable (for
how could you persuade any one not to speak of those
who are exhibited in the same nature as “many
men”?—indeed, in every case habit is a thing hard to
change), we are not so far wrong in not going contrary
to the prevailing habit in the case of the lower nature,
since no harm results from the mistaken use of the
name; but in the case of the divine dogma the various
use of terms is no longer so free from danger: for that
which is of small account is in these subjects no longer
a small matter.

Therefore we must confess one God, according to the
testimony of Scripture, “Hear, O Israel, the Lord thy
God is one Lord,” even though the appellation of
divinity extends through the Holy Trinity. This I say
according to the account we have given in the case of
human nature, in which we have learnt that it is
improper to extend the name of the nature by the mark
of plurality. We must, however, more carefully
examine the name of *divinity*, in order to obtain, by
means of the significance involved in the word, some
help towards clearing up the question before us.

It seems to many that the word *divinity* is used in a
peculiar degree in respect of nature: and just as the
heaven, or the sun, or any other of the constituent
parts of the universe are denoted by proper names
which are significant of the subjects, so they say that in
the case of the most high and divine nature, the word
divinity is fitly adapted to that which it represents to us,
as a kind of special name. We, on the other hand,
following the suggestions of Scripture, have learnt that
that nature is unnameable and unspeakable, and we say
that every name either invented by the human custom,
or handed down to us by the Scriptures, is indeed

αὐτῆς τῆς φύσεως περιέχειν τὴν σημασίαν.

Καὶ οὐ πολλῆς ἂν τις δεηθεῖ πραγματείας πρὸς τὴν ἀπόδειξιν τοῦ ταῦτα οὕτως ἔχειν. τὰ μὲν γὰρ λοιπὰ τῶν ὀνομάτων, ὅσα ἐπὶ τῆς κτίσεως κεῖται, καὶ δίχα τινὸς ἐτυμολογίας εὗροι τις ἂν κατὰ τὸ συμβὰν ἐφηρμοσμένα τοῖς ὑποκειμένοις, ἀγαπώντων ἡμῶν ὅπως οὖν τὰ πράγματα διὰ τῆς ἐπ' αὐτῶν φωνῆς σημειώσασθαι πρὸς τὸ ἀσυγχυτον ἡμῖν γίνεσθαι τῶν σεσημειωμένων τὴν γνῶσιν. ὅσα δὲ πρὸς ὁδηγίαν τῆς θείας κατανοήσεως ἐστὶν ὀνόματα, ἰδίαν ἔχει ἕκαστον ἐμπεριελημμένην διάνοιαν καὶ οὐκ ἂν χωρὶς νοήματός τινος οὐδεμίαν εὗροις φωνὴν ἐν τοῖς θεοπρεπεστέροις τῶν ὀνομάτων, ὥς ἐκ τούτου δείκνυσθαι μὴ αὐτὴν τὴν θεϊαν φύσιν ὑπὸ τινος τῶν ὀνομάτων σεσημειῶσθαι, ἀλλὰ τὴν περὶ αὐτὴν διὰ τῶν λεγομένων γνωρίζεσθαι. λέγομεν γὰρ εἶναι τὸ θεῖον ἀφθαρτον, εἰ οὕτω τύχοι, ἢ δυνατόν ἢ ὅσα ἄλλα σύνηθές ἐστι λέγειν.

ἀλλ' εὐρίσκομεν ἕκαστου τῶν ὀνομάτων ἰδιαζουσαν ἔμφασιν πρέπουσαν περὶ τῆς θείας φύσεως νοεῖσθαι καὶ λέγεσθαι, οὐ μὴν ἐκεῖνο σημαίνουσιν, ὃ ἐστὶ κατ' οὐσίαν ἢ φύσιν· αὐτὸ γὰρ ὃ τι ποτέ ἐστίν, ἀφθαρτὸν ἐστίν· ἢ δὲ τοῦ ἀφθάρτου ἔννοια αὕτη, τὸ μὴ εἰς φθορὰν τὸ ὄν διαλύεσθαι. οὐκοῦν ἀφθαρτον εἰπόντες, ὃ μὴ πάσχει ἢ φύσιν, εἵπομεν· τί δέ ἐστι τὸ τὴν φθορὰν μὴ πάσχον, οὐ παρεστήσαμεν. οὕτω καὶ ζωοποιὸν εἵπωμεν, ὃ ποιεῖ διὰ τῆς [44] προσηγορίας σημάναντες τὸ ποιοῦν τῷ λόγῳ οὐκ ἐγνωρίσαμεν.

καὶ τὰ ἄλλα πάντα κατὰ τὸν αὐτὸν λόγον ἐκ τῆς ἐγκειμένης ταῖς θεοπρεπεστέραις φωναῖς σημασίας εὐρίσκομεν, ἢ τὸ μὴ δέον ἐπὶ τῆς θείας φύσεως γινώσκειν ἀπαγορεύοντα ἢ τὸ δέον διδάσκοντα, αὐτῆς δὲ τῆς φύσεως ἐρμηνεῖαν οὐ περιέχοντα.

Ἐπεὶ τοίνυν τὰς ποικίλας τῆς ὑπερκειμένης δυνάμεως ἐνεργείας κατανοοῦντες ἀφ' ἑκάστης τῶν ἡμῖν γνωρίμων ἐνεργειῶν τὰς προσηγορίας ἀρμόζομεν, μίαν δὲ καὶ ταύτην εἶναι λέγομεν τοῦ θεοῦ τὴν ἐνέργειαν, τὴν ἐποπτικὴν καὶ ὁρατικὴν καὶ ὥς ἂν τις εἴποι θεατικὴν, καθ' ἣν τὰ πάντα ἐφορᾷ καὶ πάντα ἐπισκοπεῖ, τὰς ἐνθυμήσεις βλέπων καὶ ἐπὶ τὰ ἀθέατα τῇ θεωρητικῇ δυνάμει διαδύομενος, ὑπειλήφαμεν ἐκ τῆς θεάς τὴν θεότητα παρωνομάσθαι καὶ τὸν θεωρὸν ἡμῶν θεὸν ὑπὸ τῆς συνηθείας καὶ τῆς τῶν γραφῶν διδασκαλίας προσαγορεύεσθαι.

Εἰ δὲ συγχωρεῖ τις ταῦτόν εἶναι τὸ θεᾶσθαι τῷ βλέπειν καὶ τὸν ἐφορῶντα πάντα θεὸν ἔφορον τοῦ παντός καὶ εἶναι καὶ λέγεσθαι, λογισάσθω τὴν ἐνέργειαν ταύτην, πότερον ἐνὶ πρόσεστι τῶν ἐν τῇ ἁγίᾳ τριάδι

explanatory of the things understood to be *around* the divine nature, but does not include the designation of that nature itself.

And it may be shown without much difficulty that this is the case. For all other names which are applied to the creation may be found, even without analysis of their origin, to be applied to the subjects accidentally, because we are content to denote the things in any way by the word applied to them so as to avoid confusion in our knowledge of the things signified. But all the terms that are employed to lead us to the knowledge of God have each its own meaning encompassed in them, and you cannot find any word among the names especially applied to God which is without a distinct sense. Hence it is clear that by any of the names we use the divine nature itself is not signified, but some one of the things *around/about* it are made known. For we say, it may be, that the divine is incorruptible, or powerful, or whatever else we are accustomed to say.

But in each of these terms we find a peculiar sense, fit to be understood or asserted *about* the divine nature, yet not expressing that which that nature is in its essence. For the subject, whatever it may be, is incorruptible: but our conception of incorruptibility is this: that that which is, is not resolved into decay. So, when we say that [the divine] is incorruptible, we declare what the nature does not suffer, but we do not express what is that which does not suffer corruption. Thus, again, if we say that it is lifegiving, though we show by that appellation what he gives, we do not by that word declare what that is which gives it. And by the same reasoning we find that all else which results from the significance implied in the names befitting God either forbids us to conceive what we ought not to conceive of the divine nature, or teaches us that which we ought to conceive of it, but does not include an explanation of the nature itself.

Since, then, as we perceive the manifold operations/energies of the power above, we fashion our appellations from the each of the *energeiai* that are known to us, and as we recognize as one of these that the energy of oversight and vision, or, as one might call it, beholding, whereby he observes all things and looks over them all, discerning our thoughts, and even entering by his power of contemplation into those things which are not visible, we suppose that the divinity (*theotês*), is so called from *thea* or seeing, and that He who beholds us, by customary use and by the teaching of the Scriptures, is called *theos*.

Now if any one admits that to behold and to look are the same thing, and that God who oversees all things, both is and is called the Overseer of all, let him consider this energy, and judge whether it belongs to

πεπιστευμένων προσώπων ἢ διὰ τῶν τριῶν διήκει ἡ δύναμις. εἰ γὰρ ἀληθὴς ἡ τῆς θεότητος ἐρμηνεία καὶ τὰ ὀρώμενα θεατὰ καὶ τὸ θεώμενον θεὸς [45] λέγεται, οὐκέτι ἂν εὐλόγως ἀποκριθεῖ τι τῶν ἐν τῇ τριάδι προσώπων τῆς τοιαύτης προσηγορίας διὰ τὴν ἐγκειμένην τῇ φωνῇ σημασίαν. τὸ γὰρ βλέπειν ἐπίσης μαρτυρεῖ ἡ γραφὴ καὶ πατρὶ καὶ υἱῷ καὶ ἀγίῳ πνεύματι. Ὑπερασπιστὰ ἡμῶν, ἴδε, ὁ θεός, φησὶν ὁ Δαβίδ· ἐκ δὲ τούτου μανθάνομεν ἰδίαν θεοῦ, καθὼς θεὸς νοεῖται, ἐνέργειαν τὸ ὄραν, ἐκ τοῦ εἰπεῖν Ἴδε, ὁ θεός, ἀλλὰ καὶ ὁ Ἰησοῦς ὁρᾷ τὰς ἐνθυμήσεις τῶν καταγινωσκόντων, διότι συγχωρεῖ τὰς ἀμαρτίας ἐξ αὐθεντίας [τῶν ἀνθρώπων]. Ἰδὼν γάρ, φησὶν, ὁ Ἰησοῦς τὰς ἐνθυμήσεις αὐτῶν. καὶ περὶ τοῦ πνεύματος λέγει πρὸς τὸν Ἀνανίαν ὁ Πέτρος Ἰνα τί ἐπλήρωσεν ὁ σατανᾶς τὴν καρδίαν σου ψεύσασθαί σε τὸ πνεῦμα τὸ ἅγιον; δεικνὺς ὅτι τῶν ἐν κρυπτῷ τολμωμένων παρὰ τοῦ Ἀνανίου μάρτυς ἦν ἀψευδὴς καὶ ἐπιίστωρ τὸ πνεῦμα τὸ ἅγιον, δι' οὗ καὶ τῷ Πέτρῳ τῶν λανθανόντων ἢ φανέρωσις ἦν. ὁ μὲν γὰρ ἐγένετο κλέπτης αὐτὸς ἑαυτοῦ λανθάνων, ὡς ᾤετο, πάντας καὶ τὴν ἀμαρτίαν ἐπικρυπτόμενος· τὸ δὲ πνεῦμα τὸ ἅγιον ὁμοῦ τε ἐν Πέτρῳ ἦν καὶ τὴν ἐκείνου διάνοιαν πρὸς τὴν φιλοχρηματίαν κατασυρεῖσαν ἐφώρασε καὶ δι' ἑαυτοῦ δίδωσι τῷ Πέτρῳ διιδεῖν τὰ [46] λανθάνοντα· οὐκ ἂν δηλονότι τοῦτο ποιοῦν, εἴπερ ἦν τῶν κρυφίων ἀθέατον.

Ἄλλ' οὕτω τις ἐρεῖ πρὸς τὸ ζητούμενον βλέπειν τὴν κατασκευὴν τοῦ λόγου. οὐδὲ γὰρ εἰ δοθεῖ κοινὴ τῆς φύσεως ἢ κλήσις τῆς θεότητος εἶναι, ἤδη τὸ μὴ δεῖν λέγειν θεοὺς διὰ τούτου κατεσκευάσθη. τούναντίον μὲν οὖν ἐκ τούτων ἀναγκαζόμεθα μᾶλλον λέγειν θεοὺς. εὐρίσκομεν γὰρ ἐπὶ τῆς ἀνθρωπίνης συνηθείας οὐ μόνον τοὺς τῆς αὐτῆς φύσεως κοινωνοὺς ἀλλὰ, καὶ τινες τοῦ αὐτοῦ ὥσιν ἐπιτηδεύματος, οὐχ ἐνικῶς τοὺς πολλοὺς μνημονευομένους καθὼς φαμεν ῥήτορας τε πολλοὺς καὶ γεωμέτρους γεωργοὺς τε καὶ κυτοτόμους καὶ τὰ ἄλλα πάντα ὡσαύτως.

καὶ εἰ μὲν φύσεως ἦν ἡ τῆς θεότητος προσηγορία, μᾶλλον ἂν εἶχε καιρὸν κατὰ τὸν προαποδοθέντα λόγον ἐνικῶς τὰς τρεῖς ὑποστάσεις περιλαμβάνειν καὶ ἓνα θεὸν λέγειν διὰ τὸ τῆς φύσεως ἄτμητόν τε καὶ ἀδιαίρετον· ἐπεὶ δὲ κατεσκευάσθη διὰ τῶν εἰρημένων ἐνέργειαν σημαίνειν καὶ οὐχὶ φύσιν τὸ τῆς θεότητος ὄνομα, περιτρέπεται πῶς πρὸς τούναντίον ἐκ τῶν κατασκευαζομένων ὁ λόγος, ὡς δεῖν ταύτη μᾶλλον λέγειν τρεῖς θεοὺς τοὺς ἐν τῇ αὐτῇ ἐνεργείᾳ θεωρουμένους ὥς φασι τρεῖς λέγεσθαι φιλοσόφους ἢ ῥήτορας ἢ εἰ τί ἐστὶν ἕτερον ἐξ ἐπιτηδεύματος ὄνομα, ὅταν πλείους ὥσιν οἱ τοῦ αὐτοῦ συμμετέχοντες.

one of the persons/*prosopa* whom we believe in the Holy Trinity, or whether the power pervades throughout the Three. For if our interpretation of the term “divinity” is a true one, and the things which are seen are said to be beheld, or *theata*, and that which beholds them is called *theos*, no one of the persons/*prosopa* in the Trinity could reasonably be excluded from such an appellation on the ground of the sense involved in the word. For Scripture attributes the seeing equally to Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. David says, “See, O God our defender” (Ps 84:9), and from this we learn that sight is a proper energy of God, so far as God is conceived, since he says, “See, O God.” But Jesus also sees the thoughts of those who condemn Him, and questions why by His own power He pardons the sins of men? For it says, “Jesus, seeing their thoughts” (Matt 9:4). And of the Holy Spirit also, Peter says to Ananias, “Why hath Satan filled thine heart, to lie to the Holy Spirit?” (Acts 5:3), showing that the Holy Spirit was a true witness, aware of what Ananias had dared to do in secret, and by the Spirit the manifestation of the hidden things was made to Peter. For Ananias became a thief of his own goods, secretly, as he thought, from all men, and concealing his sin: but the Holy Spirit at the same moment was in Peter, and detected his intent, dragged down as it was to avarice, and gave to Peter from himself the power of seeing the secret, while it is clear that He could not have done this had He not been able to behold hidden things.

But some one will say that the proof of our argument does not yet regard the question. For even if it were granted that the name of *divinity* is a common name of the nature, it would not be established that we should not speak of “gods.” But by these arguments, on the contrary, we are compelled to speak of “Gods,” for we find in the human custom that not only those who are partakers of the same nature, but even any who may be of the same occupation, are not, when they are many, spoken of in the singular, since we speak of many orators, or surveyors, or farmers, or shoemakers, and so in all other cases.

If, indeed, divinity were an appellation of nature, it would be more proper, according to the argument laid down, to include the three *hypostases* in the singular number, and to speak of “One God,” by reason of the inseparability and indivisibility of the nature: but since it has been established by what has been said, that the term “divinity” is significant of operation/*energeia*, and not of nature, the argument from what has been advanced seems to turn to the contrary conclusion, that we ought therefore all the more to call those “three Gods” who are contemplated in the same operation, as they say that one would speak of “three philosophers” or “orators,” or any other name derived from a business when those who take part in the same

ταῦτα φιλοπονώτερον ἐξεργασάμην, τὸν [47] τῶν ὑπεναντίων ἀνθυποφέρων λόγον, ὡς ἂν βεβαιότερον ἡμῖν παγείῃ τὸ δόγμα ταῖς εὐτονωτέραις τῶν ἀντιθέσεων κρατυνόμενον. οὐκοῦν ἐπαναληπτέος πάλιν ὁ λόγος.

Ἐπειδὴ μετρίως ἡμῖν ἐκ τῆς κατασκευῆς ἀπεδείχθη οὗ φύσεως ἄλλ' ἐνεργείας εἶναι τὴν φωνὴν τῆς θεότητος, τάχα ταύτην ἂν τις αἰτίαν εὐλόγως εἴποι τοῦ πληθυντικῶς μὲν ἐπ' ἀνθρώπων τοὺς τῶν αὐτῶν ἐπιτηδευμάτων κοινωνοῦντας ἀλλήλοις ἀριθμεῖσθαι καὶ ὀνομάζεσθαι, μοναδικῶς δὲ τὸ θεῖον ὡς ἓνα θεὸν καὶ μίαν θεότητα λέγεσθαι, κἂν αἱ τρεῖς ὑποστάσεις τῆς ἐμφαινομένης τῇ θεότητι σημασίας μὴ ἀποκρίνιντο, ὅτι ἄνθρωποι μὲν, κἂν μιᾷ ὥσιν ἐνεργείας οἱ πλείονες, καθ' ἑαυτὸν ἕκαστος ἀποτεταγμένως ἐνεργεῖ τὸ προκείμενον, οὐδὲν ἐπικοινωνῶν ἐν τῇ καθ' ἑαυτὸν ἐνεργείᾳ πρὸς τοὺς τὸ ἴσον ἐπιτηδεύοντας· εἰ γὰρ καὶ πλείονες εἶεν οἱ ῥήτορες, τὸ μὲν ἐπιτήδευμα ἐν ᾧ τὸ αὐτὸ ἐν τοῖς πλείοσιν ὄνομα ἔχει, οἱ δὲ μετιόντες καθ' ἑαυτὸν ἕκαστος ἐνεργοῦσιν ἰδίως ῥητορεύων ὁ δεῖνα καὶ ἰδίως ὁ ἕτερος· οὐκοῦν ἐν μὲν τοῖς ἀνθρώποις, ἐπειδὴ διακεκριμένη ἐστὶν ἡ ἐν τοῖς αὐτοῖς ἐπιτηδεύμασιν ἕκαστου ἐνέργεια, κυρίως πολλοὶ ὀνομάζονται, ἕκαστος αὐτῶν εἰς ἰδίαν περιγραφὴν κατὰ τὸ ἰδιότροπον τῆς ἐνεργείας ἀποτεμνομένου τῶν ἄλλων·

ἐπὶ δὲ τῆς θείας φύσεως οὐχ οὕτως ἐμάθομεν ὅτι ὁ πατὴρ ποιεῖ τι καθ' ἑαυτόν, οὐ μὴ συνεφέπτεται ὁ υἱός, ἢ πάλιν ὁ υἱὸς ἰδιαζόντως ἐνεργεῖ τι χωρὶς τοῦ πνεύματος, ἀλλὰ πᾶσα ἐνέργεια ἡ θεόθεν ἐπὶ τὴν κτίσιν διήκουσα καὶ κατὰ τὰς πολυτρόπους [48] ἐννοίας ὀνομαζομένη ἐκ πατρὸς ἀφορμᾶται καὶ διὰ τοῦ υἱοῦ πρόεισι καὶ ἐν τῷ πνεύματι τῷ ἁγίῳ τελειοῦται. διὰ τοῦτο εἰς τὸ πλῆθος τῶν ἐνεργούντων τὸ ὄνομα τῆς ἐνεργείας οὐ διασχίζεται, ὅτι οὐκ ἀποτεταγμένη ἕκαστου καὶ ἰδιαζουσα ἐστὶν ἡ περὶ τι σπουδὴ· ἄλλ' ὅπερ ἂν γίνηται τῶν εἴτε εἰς τὴν ἡμετέραν πρόνοιαν φθανόντων εἴτε πρὸς τὴν τοῦ παντὸς οἰκονομίαν καὶ σύστασιν, διὰ τῶν τριῶν μὲν γίνεται, οὐ μὴν τρία ἐστὶ τὰ γινόμενα.

Νοήσωμεν δὲ τὸ λεγόμενον ἅφ' ἑνός τινος πράγματος, ἀπ' αὐτοῦ λέγω τοῦ κεφαλαίου τῶν χαρισμάτων. ζωῆς τετύχηκεν, ὅσα μετέληφε τῆς χάριτος ταύτης. ἐξετάζοντες οὖν πόθεν ἡμῖν τὸ τοιοῦτον γέγονεν ἀγαθόν, εὐρίσκομεν διὰ τῆς τῶν γραφῶν ὁδηγίας, ὅτι ἐκ πατρὸς καὶ υἱοῦ καὶ πνεύματος ἁγίου.

business are more than one.

I have taken some pains, in setting forth this view, to bring forward the reasoning on behalf of the adversaries, that our decision may be the more firmly fixed, being strengthened by the more elaborate contradictions. Let us now resume our argument.

Since we have to a certain extent shown by our statement that the word *divinity* does not designate nature but operation/energy, perhaps one might reasonably allege as a cause why, in the case of men, those who share with one another in the same pursuits are enumerated and spoken of in the plural, while on the other hand the divine is spoken of in the singular as one God and one divinity, even though the three *hypostases* are not separated from the designation expressed by the term *divinity*. One might allege, I say, the fact that men, even if several are engaged in the same form of *energy*, work separately each by himself at the task he has undertaken, having no participation in his individual *energy* with others who are engaged in the same occupation. For instance, supposing the case of several rhetoricians, their pursuit, being one, has the same name in the numerous cases, but each of those who follow it works by himself, this one pleading on his own account, and that on his own account. Thus, since among men the *energy* of each in the same pursuits is differentiated, they are properly called many, since each of them is separated from the others within his own environment, according to the special character of his operation/energy.

But in the case of the divine nature we do not similarly learn that the Father does anything by Himself in which the Son does not involved together, or again that the Son operates anything peculiar apart from the Spirit; but every operation which extends from God to the creation, and is named according to our manifold conceptions, has its origin from the Father, and proceeds through the Son, and is perfected in the Holy Spirit. For this reason the name derived from the operation is not divided with regard to the number of those who fulfil it, because the action of each concerning anything is not separate and peculiar, but whatever comes to pass, in reference either to the acts of his providence for us, or to the economy and composition of the universe, comes to pass through the Three, yet what does come to pass is not three things.

We may understand the meaning of this from one single instance, from Him, I say, who is the chief source of the charisms. All things which have shared in this grace have obtained their life. When we inquire, then, whence this good thing came to us, we find by the guidance of the Scriptures that it was from the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

ἀλλ' οὐκ, ἐπειδὴ τρία ὑποτιθέμεθα πρόσωπά τε καὶ ὀνόματα, τρεῖς καὶ ζωὰς (ἰδίως μίαν παρ' ἐκάστου αὐτῶν) δεδωρῆσθαι ἡμῖν λογιζόμεθα, ἀλλ' ἡ αὐτὴ ζωὴ καὶ παρὰ τοῦ ἁγίου πνεύματος ἐνεργεῖται καὶ παρὰ τοῦ υἱοῦ ἐτοιμάζεται καὶ τῆς τοῦ πατρὸς ἐξήπται βουλήσεως.

Ἐπειδὴ τοίνυν καθ' ὁμοιότητα τοῦ εἰρημένου πᾶσαν ἐνέργειαν οὐ διηρημένως ἐνεργεῖ κατὰ τὸν τῶν ὑποστάσεων ἀριθμὸν ἢ ἁγία τριάς, ἀλλὰ μία τις γίνεται τοῦ ἀγαθοῦ θελήματος κίνησις τε καὶ διάδοσις, ἐκ τοῦ πατρὸς διὰ τοῦ [49] υἱοῦ πρὸς τὸ πνεῦμα διεξαγομένη, ὡς οὐ λέγομεν τρεῖς ζωοποιούς τοὺς τὴν μίαν ἐνεργοῦντας ζῶν οὐδὲ τρεῖς ἀγαθοὺς τοὺς ἐν τῇ αὐτῇ ἀγαθότητι θεωρουμένους οὐδὲ τὰ ἄλλα πάντα πληθυντικῶς ἐξαγγέλλομεν, οὕτως οὐδὲ τρεῖς ὀνομάζειν δυνάμεθα τοὺς τὴν θεϊκὴν ταύτην ἡτοι ἐποπτικὴν δύναμιν τε καὶ ἐνέργειαν συνημμένως καὶ ἀδιακρίτως δι' ἀλλήλων ἐφ' ἡμῶν τε καὶ πάσης τῆς κτίσεως ἐνεργοῦντας.

ὥσπερ γὰρ μαθόντες περὶ τοῦ θεοῦ τῶν ὅλων τῆς γραφῆς λεγούσης κρίνειν αὐτὸν πᾶσαν τὴν γῆν κριτὴν τοῦ παντὸς αὐτὸν εἶναι διὰ τοῦτο φαμεν καὶ πάλιν ἀκούσαντες ὅτι Ὁ πατὴρ κρίνει οὐδένα οὐχ ἡγούμεθα μάχεσθαι πρὸς αὐτὴν τὴν γραφὴν· ὁ γὰρ κρίνων πᾶσαν τὴν γῆν διὰ τοῦ υἱοῦ, ὃ πᾶσαν δέδωκε τὴν κρίσιν, τοῦτο ποιεῖ καὶ πᾶν τὸ παρὰ τοῦ μονογενοῦς γινόμενον εἰς τὸν πατέρα τὴν ἀναφορὰν ἔχει, ὥστε καὶ κριτὴν αὐτὸν τοῦ παντὸς εἶναι καὶ κρίνειν μηδένα διὰ τὸ πᾶσαν, ὡς εἴρηται, τὴν κρίσιν τῷ υἱῷ δεδωκέναι καὶ πᾶσαν τὴν τοῦ υἱοῦ κρίσιν τοῦ πατρικοῦ μὴ ἀπηλλοτριῶσθαι βουλήματος καὶ οὐκ ἂν τις εὐλόγως ἢ δύο κριτὰς εἴποι ἢ τὸν ἕτερον ἡλλοτριῶσθαι τῆς κατὰ τὴν κρίσιν ἐξουσίας τε καὶ δυνάμεως οὕτω καὶ ἐπὶ τοῦ τῆς θεότητος λόγου [50] Χριστὸς θεοῦ δυνάμεις καὶ θεοῦ σοφία καὶ τὴν ἐποπτικὴν τε καὶ θεατικὴν δύναμιν, ἥνπερ δὴ θεότητα λέγομεν, διὰ τοῦ μονογενοῦς ὁ πατὴρ ἐνεργεῖ, ὅ πάντα ἐν σοφίᾳ ποιῶν θεός, τοῦ δὲ υἱοῦ πᾶσαν δύναμιν ἐν τῷ ἁγίῳ πνεύματι τελειοῦντος καὶ κρίνοντος μὲν, καθὼς Ἡσαΐας φησὶν, ἐν πνεύματι κρίσεως καὶ πνεύματι καύσεως, εὐεργετοῦντος δὲ κατὰ τὴν τοῦ εὐαγγελίου φωνήν, ἥν πρὸς τοὺς Ἰουδαίους πεποίηται, ἐν πνεύματι θεοῦ· λέγει γὰρ Εἰ δὲ ἐγὼ ἐν πνεύματι θεοῦ ἐκβάλλω τὰ δαιμόνια· ἀπὸ μέρους πᾶν εἶδος εὐεργεσίας περιλαμβάνων διὰ τῆς κατὰ τὴν ἐνέργειαν ἐνότητος· οἷς γὰρ δι' ἀλλήλων ἐνεργεῖται τὸ ἔν, εἰς πολλοὺς καταμεμερίσθαι τὸ ὄνομα τῆς ἐνεργείας οὐ δύναται.

Ἐπειδὴ γὰρ εἷς ὁ τῆς ἐποπτικῆς τε καὶ θεατικῆς δυνάμεως λόγος ἐν πατρὶ καὶ υἱῷ καὶ πνεύματι ἁγίῳ, καθὼς ἐν τοῖς ἔμπροσθεν εἴρηται, ἐκ μὲν τοῦ πατρὸς οἷον ἐκ πηγῆς τινος ἀφορμώμενος, ὑπὸ δὲ τοῦ υἱοῦ

Yet although we set forth three persons/*prosopa* and three names, we do not consider that we have had bestowed upon us three lives, one from each (Person) separately; but the same life is wrought in us by the Holy Spirit, and is prepared by the Son, and is dependent upon the will of the Father.

Since then the Holy Trinity fulfils every operation in a manner similar to that of which I have spoken, not separately according to the number of the *hypostases*, but so that there is one motion and distribution of the good will which is communicated from the Father through the Son to the Spirit. For as we do not call those whose operation gives one life “three life-givers”, neither do we call those who are contemplated in one goodness “three good beings,” nor speak of them in the plural by any of their other attributes, so neither can we call “three” those who through each other, jointly and inseparably, work this divine and overseeing power and operation towards ourselves and all creation.

For as when we learn concerning the God of all, from the words of Scripture, that He judges all the earth (Rom 3:6), we say that He is the Judge of all things – therefore again, when we hear that the Father judgeth no man (John 5:22), we do not think that the Scripture is at variance with itself, for He Who judges all the earth does this by His Son to Whom He has committed all judgment. And everything which is done by the Only-begotten has its reference to the Father, so that He Himself is at once the Judge of all things and judges no man, by reason of His having, as we said, committed all judgment to the Son, while all the judgment of the Son is not estranged from the will of the Father. And one could not properly say either that they are two judges, or that one of them is excluded from the authority and power implied in judgment. So also in the case of the word *divinity*, Christ is the power of God and the wisdom of God, and that very power of oversight and beholding which we call divinity, the Father exercises through the Only-begotten, while the Son perfects every power by the Holy Spirit, judging, as Isaiah says, by the Spirit of judgment and the Spirit of burning (Isa 4:4), and acting by Him also, according to the saying in the Gospel which was spoken to the Jews, in the Spirit of God. For He says, “If I by the Spirit of God cast out devils” (Matt 12:28), where He includes every form of doing good in a partial description, by reason of the unity of action, for the name of the operation cannot be divided into many where the result of their mutual operation is one.

Since, then, the character of the overseeing and beholding power is one, in Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, as has been said above, issuing from the Father as from a source, operated by the Son, and perfecting its grace

ἐνεργούμενος, ἐν δὲ τῇ δυνάμει τοῦ πνεύματος τελειῶν τὴν χάριν, καὶ οὐ διακρίνεται πρὸς τὰς ὑποστάσεις οὐδεμία ἐνέργεια, ἰδιαζόντως παρ' ἐκάστης καὶ ἀποτεταγμένως δίχα τῆς συνθεωρουμένης ἐπιτελουμένη· ἀλλὰ πᾶσα πρόνοια καὶ κηδεμονία καὶ τοῦ [51] παντὸς ἐπιστάσις, τῶν τε κατὰ τὴν αἰσθητὴν κτίσιν καὶ τῶν κατὰ τὴν ὑπερκόσμιον φύσιν ἢ τε συντηρητικὴ τῶν ὄντων καὶ διορθωτικὴ τῶν πλημμελουμένων καὶ διδακτικὴ τῶν κατορθουμένων, μία ἐστὶ καὶ οὐχὶ τρεῖς, παρὰ μὲν τῆς ἁγίας τριάδος κατορθουμένη, οὐ μὴν κατὰ τὸν ἀριθμὸν τῶν ἐν τῇ πίστει θεωρουμένων προσώπων τριχῇ τεμνομένη, ὡς ἕκαστον τῶν ἐνεργημάτων ἐφ' ἑαυτοῦ θεωρούμενον ἢ τοῦ πατρὸς εἶναι μόνου ἢ τοῦ μονογενοῦς ἰδιαζόντως ἢ τοῦ ἁγίου πνεύματος κεχωρισμένως· ἀλλὰ διαιρεῖ μὲν ἰδίᾳ ἐκάστῳ τὰ ἀγαθὰ, καθὼς φησιν ὁ ἀπόστολος, τὸ ἐν καὶ τὸ αὐτὸ πνεῦμα· οὐκ ἄναρχος δὲ ἡ τοῦ ἀγαθοῦ κίνησις ἐκ τοῦ πνεύματος· ἀλλ' εὐρίσκομεν ὅτι ἡ προεπινοούμενη ταύτης δύναμις, ἣτις ἐστὶν ὁ μονογενὴς θεός, πάντα ποιεῖ, οὐ χωρὶς οὐδὲν τῶν ὄντων εἰς γένεσιν ἔρχεται· ἀλλὰ καὶ αὐτὴ πάλιν τῶν ἀγαθῶν ἡ πηγὴ ἐκ τοῦ πατρικοῦ βουλήματος ἀφορμᾶται.

Εἰ δὴ πᾶν ἀγαθὸν πρᾶγμα καὶ ὄνομα τῆς ἀνάρχου δυνάμεως τε καὶ βουλῆς ἐξημμένον ἐν τῇ δυνάμει τοῦ πνεύματος διὰ τοῦ μονογενοῦς θεοῦ ἀχρόνως καὶ ἀδιαστάτως εἰς τελείωσιν ἄγεται, οὐδεμιᾶς παρατάσεως ἐν τῇ τοῦ θείου βουλήματος κινήσει ἀπὸ τοῦ πατρὸς διὰ τοῦ υἱοῦ ἐπὶ τὸ πνεῦμα γινομένης ἢ νοουμένης, ἐν δὲ τῶν ἀγαθῶν ὀνομάτων τε καὶ νοημάτων καὶ ἡ θεότης, οὐκ ἂν εἰκότως εἰς πληθος τὸ [52] ὄνομα διαχέοιτο, τῆς κατὰ τὴν ἐνέργειαν ἐνότητος κωλυούσης τὴν πληθυντικὴν ἀπαριθμῆσιν.

Καὶ ὥσπερ εἷς ὁ πατὴρ σωτὴρ πάντων ἀνθρώπων μάλιστα πιστῶν ὑπὸ τοῦ ἀποστόλου ὠνόμασται καὶ οὐδεὶς ἐκ τῆς φωνῆς ταύτης ἢ τὸν υἱὸν λέγει μὴ σῶζειν τοὺς πιστεύοντας ἢ δίχα τοῦ πνεύματος τὴν σωτηρίαν τοῖς μετέχουσι γίνεσθαι, ἀλλὰ γίνεται πάντων σωτὴρ ὁ ἐπὶ πάντων θεὸς ἐνεργούντος τοῦ υἱοῦ τὴν σωτηρίαν ἐν τῇ τοῦ πνεύματος χάριτι καὶ οὐδὲν μᾶλλον διὰ τοῦτο τρεῖς σωτῆρες ὑπὸ τῆς γραφῆς ὀνομάζονται, εἰ καὶ ὁμολογεῖται παρὰ τῆς ἁγίας τριάδος ἡ σωτηρία, οὕτως οὐδὲ τρεῖς θεοὶ κατὰ τὴν ἀποδοδεδομένην τῆς θεότητος σημασίαν, κἂν ἐφαρμόζη τῇ ἁγίᾳ τριάδι ἡ τοιαύτη κλήσις.

μάχεσθαι δὲ πρὸς τοὺς ἀντιλέγοντας μὴ δεῖν ἐνέργειαν νοεῖν τὴν θεότητα οὐ πᾶν τι τῶν ἀναγκαίων μοι δοκεῖ, ὡς πρὸς τὴν παροῦσαν τοῦ λόγου κατασκευήν. ἡμεῖς μὲν γὰρ ὀρίστον καὶ ἀπερίληπτον τὴν θείαν φύσιν εἶναι πιστεύοντες οὐδεμίαν αὐτῆς ἐπινοοῦμεν περίληψιν, ἀλλὰ κατὰ πάντα τρόπον ἐν ἀπειρίᾳ νοεῖσθαι τὴν φύσιν διορίζομεθα. τὸ δὲ καθόλου ἄπειρον οὐ τινὶ μὲν ὀρίζεται, τινὶ δὲ οὐχί· ἀλλὰ κατὰ πάντα

by the power of the Spirit, and since no operation is distinguished into the *hypostases*, being fulfilled by each individually apart from that which is joined with Him in our contemplation, but all providence, care, and authority over all, alike of things in the perceptible creation and of those of nature of the world above, and that power which preserves the things which are, and corrects those which are amiss, and instructs those which are ordered aright, is one, and not three, being, indeed, directed by the Holy Trinity, yet not severed by a threefold division according to the number of the persons/*prosopa* contemplated by the faith, so that each of the acts, contemplated by itself, should be the work of the Father alone, or of the Only-begotten independently, or of the Holy Spirit separately. But while, as the Apostle says, the one and the same Spirit divides His good gifts to every man (1 Cor 12:11), the motion of good proceeding from the Spirit is not without beginning. We find that the power conceived before this motion, who is the Only-begotten God, makes all things, and without Him none of the things that exist comes into being; but, again, this same source of good comes forth from the will of the Father.

If, then, every good thing and every good name, depending on that power and counsel which is without beginning, is brought to perfection in the power of the Spirit through the Only-begotten God, timelessly and continuously (since there is no delay, existent or conceived, in the motion of the divine will from the Father, through the Son, to the Spirit): and if divinity also is one of the good names and concepts, it would not be proper to divide the name into a plurality, since the unity existing in the action prevents plural enumeration.

And as the Father, the Saviour of all men, specially of them that believe (1 Tim 4:10), is spoken of by the Apostle as one, and no one from this phrase argues either that the Son does not save them who believe, or that salvation is given to those who receive it without the intervention of the Spirit; but God who is over all, is the Saviour of all, while the Son works salvation by the grace of the Spirit, and yet they are not on this account called in Scripture three Saviours (although salvation is confessed to proceed from the Holy Trinity): so neither are they called three gods, according to the designation given to divinity, even though the aforesaid appellation attaches to the Holy Trinity.

It does not seem to me absolutely necessary, with a view to the present proof of our argument, to contend against those who oppose us with the assertion that we are not to conceive *divinity* as an operation. For we, believing the divine nature to be unlimited and incomprehensible, conceive no comprehension of it, but declare that the nature is to be conceived in all respects as infinite, and that which is absolutely

λόγον ἐκφεύγει τὸν ὅρον ἡ ἀπειρία. οὐκοῦν τὸ ἐκτὸς ὅρου οὐδὲ ὀνόματι πάντως ὀρίζεται. ὥς ἂν οὖν διαμένει ἐπὶ τῆς θείας φύσεως τοῦ ἀορίστου ἢ ἔννοια, ὑπὲρ πάντων ὀνομάτων [53] φαμεν εἶναι τὸ θεῖον, ἢ δὲ θεότης ἐν τῶν ὀνομάτων ἐστίν. οὐκοῦν οὐ δύναται τὸ αὐτὸ καὶ ὄνομα εἶναι καὶ ὑπὲρ πάντων ὀνομάτων εἶναι νομίζεσθαι.

Πλὴν εἰ τοῦτο τοῖς ἐναντίοις ἀρέσκοι, τὸ μὴ ἐνεργείας ἀλλὰ φύσεως εἶναι τὴν σημασίαν, ἐπαναδραμούμεθα πρὸς τὸν ἐξ ἀρχῆς λόγον, ὅτι τὸ τῆς φύσεως ὄνομα ἡμαρτημένως ἢ συνήθεια εἰς πλήθους σημασίαν ἀνάγει, οὔτε μειώσεως οὔτε αὐξήσεως κατὰ τὸν ἀληθῆ λόγον προσγινομένης τῇ φύσει, ὅταν ἐν πλείοσιν ἢ ἐλάττοσι θεωρῇται. μόνα γὰρ κατὰ σύνθεσιν ἀριθμεῖται, ὅσα κατ' ἰδίαν περιγραφὴν θεωρεῖται· ἢ δὲ περιγραφὴ ἐν ἐπιφανείᾳ σώματος καὶ μεγέθει καὶ τόπῳ καὶ τῇ διαφορᾷ τῇ κατὰ τὸ σχῆμα καὶ χρῶμα καταλαμβάνεται· τὸ δὲ ἕξω τούτων θεωρούμενον ἐκφεύγει τὴν διὰ τῶν τοιούτων περιγραφὴν. ὃ δὲ μὴ περιγράφεται οὐκ ἀριθμεῖται, τὸ δὲ μὴ ἀριθμούμενον ἐν πλήθει θεωρηθῆναι οὐ δύναται. ἐπεὶ καὶ τὸν χρυσόν φαμεν, καὶ εἰς πολλοὺς διακερματίζεται τύπους, ἓνα καὶ εἶναι καὶ λέγεσθαι· πολλὰ δὲ νομίσματα καὶ πολλοὺς στατήρας ὀνομάζομεν, οὐδένα τῆς φύσεως τοῦ χρυσοῦ πλεονασμὸν ἐν τῷ πλήθει τῶν στατήρων εὐρίσκοντες. διὸ καὶ πολλὸς ὁ χρυσὸς λέγεται, ὅταν ἐν ὅγκῳ πλείονι ἢ σκεύεσιν ἢ νομίσμασι θεωρῇται, πολλοὶ δὲ οἱ χρυσοὶ διὰ τὸ πλῆθος τῆς ὕλης οὐκ ὀνομάζονται· εἰ μὴ τις οὕτω λέγοι, χρυσοὺς πολλοὺς, ὥς τοὺς δαρεικοὺς ἢ τοὺς στατήρας, ἐφ' ὧν οὐχ ἡ ὕλη ἀλλὰ τὰ κέρματα τὴν τοῦ πλῆθους σημασίαν ἐδέξατο. κυρίως γὰρ ἔστιν οὐχὶ χρυσοὺς ἀλλὰ χρυσέους [54] τούτους εἰπεῖν. ὥσπερ τοίνυν πολλοὶ μὲν οἱ χρυσεοὶ στατήρες, χρυσὸς δὲ εἷς, οὕτω καὶ πολλοὶ μὲν οἱ καθ' ἕκαστον ἐν τῇ φύσει τοῦ ἀνθρώπου δεικνύμενοι, οἷον Πέτρος καὶ Ἰάκωβος καὶ Ἰωάννης, εἷς δὲ ἐν τούτοις ὁ ἄνθρωπος. καὶ ἡ γραφὴ πλατύνῃ τὸ ὄνομα κατὰ πληθυντικὴν σημασίαν ἐν τῷ λέγειν Ἄνθρωποι κατὰ τοῦ μείζονος ὁμνύουσι καὶ Υἱοὶ ἀνθρώπων, καὶ ὅσα τοιαῦτα, γνωστέον ὅτι τῇ συνηθείᾳ τῆς ἐπικρατούσης διαλέκτου κεχρημένη οὐχὶ νομοθετεῖ τὸ δεῖν οὕτως ἢ ὥς ἐτέρως κεχρηθῆναι τοῖς ῥήμασιν οὐδὲ τινὰ τεχνικὴν περὶ ῥημάτων διδασκαλίαν ποιουμένη ταῦτα διέξεισιν, ἀλλὰ κατὰ τὴν ἐπικρατοῦσαν συνήθειαν χρῆται τῷ λόγῳ, πρὸς τοῦτο βλέπουσα μόνον, ὅπως ἂν ἐπωφελὴς γένοιτο τοῖς δεχομένοις ὁ λόγος, οὐδὲν ἀκριβολογουμένη κατὰ τὴν λέξιν, ἐν οἷς οὐδεμία βλάβη κατὰ διάνοιαν ἐκ τῶν ῥημάτων συνίσταται.

infinite is not limited in one respect while it is left unlimited in another, but infinity is free from limitation altogether. That therefore which is without limit is surely not limited even by name. In order then to mark the constancy of our conception of infinity in the case of the divine nature, we say that the divine is above every name, and *divinity* is one of the names. Now it cannot be that the same thing should at once be a name and be accounted as above every name.

But if it pleases our adversaries to say that the name signifies not operation, but nature, we shall fall back upon our original argument, that custom applies the name of a nature to denote multitude erroneously. Since according to true reasoning, neither diminution nor increase attaches to any nature, when it is contemplated in a larger or smaller number. For it is only those things which are contemplated in their individual circumscription which are enumerated by way of addition. Now this circumscription is noted by bodily appearance, and size, and place, and difference figure and colour, and that which is contemplated apart from these conditions is free from the circumscription which is formed by such categories. That which is not thus circumscribed is not enumerated, and that which is not enumerated cannot be contemplated in multitude. For we say that gold, even though it be cut into many figures, is one, and is so spoken of, but we speak of many coins or many staters, without finding any multiplication of the nature of gold by the number of staters, and for this reason we speak of gold, when it is contemplated in greater bulk, either in plate or in coin, as “much,” but we do not speak of it as “many golds” on account of the multitude of the material, except when one says there are “many gold pieces” (Persian coins, for instance, or staters), in which case it is not the material, but the pieces of money to which the designation of number applies. Indeed, properly, we should not call them “gold” but “golden.” As, then, the golden staters are many, but the gold is one, so too those who are exhibited to us one by one in the nature of man, as Peter, James, and John, are many, yet the man in them is one. And although Scripture extends the word according to the plural significance, where it says “men swear by the greater,” and “sons of men,” and in other phrases of the like sort, we must recognize that in using the custom of the prevailing form of speech, it does not lay down a law as to the propriety of using the words in one way or another, nor does it say these things by way of giving us instruction about phrases, but uses the word according to the prevailing custom, with a view only to this, that the word may be profitable to those who receive it, taking no minute care in its manner of speech about points where no harm can result from the phrases in respect of the way they are understood.

Καὶ μακρὸν ἂν εἴη τὰς σολοικοφανεῖς τοῦ λόγου συντάξεις ἐκ τῆς γραφῆς καταλέγειν εἰς τὴν τῶν εἰρημένων ἀπόδειξιν· ἐν οἷς δὲ κίνδυνός ἐστι βλαβῆναι τι τῆς ἀληθείας, οὐκέτι τὸ ἀβασάνιστόν τε καὶ ἀδιάφορον ἐν τοῖς γραφικοῖς εὐρίσκεται ῥήμασιν. διὰ τοῦτο ἀνθρώπους συγχωρεῖ πληθυντικῶς ὀνομάζειν διὰ τὸ μηδένα τῷ τοιοῦτῳ σχήματι τῆς φωνῆς εἰς πληθος ἀνθρωποτήτων ταῖς ὑπονοίαις ἐκπίπτειν, μηδὲ νομίζειν πολλὰς ἀνθρωπίνας φύσεις σημαίνεισθαι διὰ τὸ πληθυντικῶς ἐξαγγελθῆναι τὸ τῆς φύσεως ὄνομα· τὴν δὲ θεὸς φωνὴν παρατετηρημένως κατὰ τὸν ἐνικὸν ἐξαγγέλλει [55] τύπον, τοῦτο προμηθευμένη, τὸ μὴ διαφόρους φύσεις ἐπὶ τῆς θείας οὐσίας ἐν τῇ πληθυντικῇ σημασίᾳ τῶν θεῶν παρεισάγεσθαι. διὸ φησι Κύριος ὁ θεὸς κύριος εἷς ἐστίν· ἀλλὰ καὶ τὸν μονογενῆ θεὸν τῇ τῆς θεότητος ἀνακηρύσσει φωνῇ καὶ οὐ διαλύει τὸ ἐν εἰς δυϊκῇ σημασίᾳ, ὥστε δύο θεοὺς τὸν πατέρα καὶ τὸν υἱὸν ὀνομάσαι, κἂν ἑκάτερος θεὸς παρὰ τῶν ἁγίων κηρύσσεται· ἀλλὰ θεὸς μὲν ὁ πατήρ, θεὸς δὲ ὁ υἱός, εἷς δὲ ἐν τῷ αὐτῷ κηρύγματι ὁ θεὸς διὰ τὸ μήτε φύσεως μήτε ἐνεργείας ἐνθεωρεῖσθαι τινα διαφορὰν τῇ θεότητι. εἰ γὰρ παρήλλακτο κατὰ τὴν τῶν ἡπατημένων ὑπόνοιαν ἐπὶ τῆς ἁγίας τριάδος ἡ φύσις, ἀκολουθῶς ἂν εἰς πληθος θεῶν ὁ ἀριθμὸς ἐπλατύνετο, τῇ ἐτερότητι τῆς οὐσίας τῶν ὑποκειμένων συνδιαιρούμενος. ἐπεὶ δὲ πᾶσαν ἀπωθεῖται τὴν κατ’ οὐσίαν ἐτερότητα ἡ θεία τε καὶ ἀπλὴ καὶ ἀναλλοίωτος φύσις, ἕως ἂν μία ᾖ, πλήθους σημασίαν ἐφ’ ἑαυτῆς οὐ προσίεται. ἀλλ’ ὥστερ μία λέγεται φύσις, οὕτω καὶ τὰ ἄλλα πάντα ἐνικῶς ὀνομάζεται, θεός, ἀγαθός, ἅγιος, σωτήρ, δίκαιος, κριτής, καὶ εἴ τι ἄλλο τῶν θεοπρεπῶν ὀνομάτων νοεῖται, ὃ εἴτε πρὸς φύσιν εἴτε πρὸς ἐνέργειαν βλέπειν τις λέγει, οὐ διοισόμεθα.

Εἰ δέ τις συκοφαντοίῃ τὸν λόγον ὡς ἐκ τοῦ μὴ δέχεσθαι τὴν κατὰ φύσιν διαφορὰν μῖξιν τινὰ τῶν ὑποστάσεων καὶ ἀνακύκλησιν κατασκευάζοντα τοῦτο περὶ τῆς τοιαύτης ἀπολογησόμεθα μέμψεως, ὅτι τὸ παράλλακτον τῆς φύσεως [56] ὁμολογοῦντες τὴν κατὰ τὸ αἷτιον καὶ αἰτιατὸν διαφορὰν οὐκ ἀρνούμεθα, ἐν ᾧ μόνῳ διακρίνεσθαι τὸ ἕτερον τοῦ ἑτέρου καταλαμβάνομεν, τῷ τὸ μὲν αἷτιον πιστεύειν εἶναι τὸ δὲ ἐκ τοῦ αἰτίου· καὶ τοῦ ἐξ αἰτίας ὄντος πάλιν ἄλλην διαφορὰν ἐννοοῦμεν· τὸ μὲν γὰρ προσεχῶς ἐκ τοῦ πρώτου, τὸ δὲ διὰ τοῦ προσεχῶς ἐκ τοῦ πρώτου, ὥστε καὶ τὸ μονογενὲς ἀναμφίβολον ἐπὶ τοῦ υἱοῦ μένειν, καὶ τὸ ἐκ τοῦ πατρὸς εἶναι τὸ πνεῦμα μὴ ἀμφιβάλλειν, τῆς τοῦ υἱοῦ μεσιτείας καὶ αὐτῷ τὸ μονογενὲς φυλαττούσης καὶ τὸ πνεῦμα τῆς φυσικῆς πρὸς τὸν πατέρα σχέσεως μὴ ἀπειργούσης.

Αἷτιον δὲ καὶ ἐξ αἰτίου λέγοντες οὐχὶ φύσιν διὰ τούτων τῶν ὀνομάτων σημαίνομεν (οὐδὲ γὰρ τὸν

Indeed, it would be a lengthy task to set out in detail from the Scriptures those constructions which are inexactly expressed, in order to prove the statement I have made; where, however, there is a risk of injury to any part of the truth, we no longer find in Scriptural phrases any indiscriminate or indifferent use of words. For this reason Scripture admits the naming of “men” in the plural, because no one is by such a figure of speech led astray in his conceptions to imagine a multitude of humanities, or supposes that many human natures are indicated by the fact that the name expressive of that nature is used in the plural. But the word God it employs studiously in the singular form only, guarding against introducing the idea of different natures in the divine essence by the plural meaning of “gods.” This is why it says, “the Lord our God is one Lord” (Deut 6:4), and also proclaims the Only-begotten God by the name of divinity, without dividing the one into a dual meaning, so as to call the Father and the Son two gods, although each is proclaimed by the holy writers as God. But the Father is God, the Son is God, and yet by the same proclamation God is one, because no difference either of nature or of operation is contemplated in the Godhead. For if (according to the idea of those who have been led astray) the nature of the Holy Trinity were diverse, the number would consequently be extended to a plurality of gods, being divided according to the diversity of essence in the subjects. But since the divine, single, and unchanging nature, that it may be one, rejects all diversity in essence, it does not admit in its own case the designation of multitude, but as it is called one nature, so it is called in the singular by all its other names, “God,” “Good,” “Holy,” “Saviour,” “Just,” “Judge,” and every other of the godly names. Whether one says that the names refer to nature or to operation, we shall not dispute the point.

If, however, any one cavils at our argument, on the ground that by not admitting the difference of nature it leads to a mixture and confusion of the *hypostases*, we shall make to such a charge this answer: that while we confess the invariable character of the nature, we do not deny the difference in respect of cause, and that which is caused, by which alone we apprehend that one is distinguished from another – by our belief, that is, that one is the Cause, and another is from the Cause, and again in that which is from the Cause we recognize another distinction. For one is directly from the first Cause, and another by that which is directly from the first Cause, so that the attribute of being Only-begotten abides without doubt in the Son, and the mediation of the Son, while it preserves His attribute of being Only-begotten, does not shut out the Spirit from His relation by way of nature to the Father.

But in speaking of “cause,” and “from the cause,” we do not by these words denote nature (for no one would

αὐτὸν ἂν τις αἰτίας καὶ φύσεως ἀποδοίῃ λόγον), ἀλλὰ τὴν κατὰ τὸ πῶς εἶναι διαφορὰν ἐνδεικνύμεθα. εἰπόντες γὰρ τὸ μὲν αἰτιατῶς τὸ δὲ ἄνευ αἰτίας εἶναι οὐχὶ τὴν φύσιν τῷ κατὰ τὸ αἴτιον λόγῳ διεχωρίσαμεν, ἀλλὰ μόνον τὸ μήτε τὸν υἱὸν ἀγεννήτως εἶναι μήτε τὸν πατέρα διὰ γεννήσεως ἐνεδειξάμεθα.

πρότερον δὲ ἡμᾶς εἶναί τι πιστεύειν ἐπάναγκες, καὶ τότε πῶς ἐστὶ τὸ πεπιστευμένον περιεργάσασθαι· ἄλλος οὖν ὁ τοῦ τί ἐστὶ καὶ ἄλλος ὁ τοῦ πῶς ἐστὶ λόγος. τὸ οὖν ἀγεννήτως εἶναί τι λέγειν, πῶς μὲν ἐστὶν ὑποτίθεται, τί δὲ ἐστὶ τῇ φωνῇ ταύτῃ οὐ συνενδείκνυται. καὶ γὰρ εἰ περὶ δένδρου τινὸς ἠρώτησας τὸν γεωργόν, εἴτε φυτευτὸν εἴτε αὐτομάτως ἐστίν, ὁ δὲ ἀπεκρίνατο ἢ ἀφύτευτον εἶναι τὸ δένδρον ἢ ἐκ φυτείας γενόμενον, ἄρα τὴν φύσιν διὰ τῆς ἀποκρίσεως ἐνεδείξατο [57] ὁ μόνον τὸ πῶς ἐστὶν εἰπὼν ἢ ἄδηλον καὶ ἀνερμήνευτον τὸν τῆς φύσεως ἀπέλιπε λόγον; οὕτω καὶ ἐνταῦθα ἀγέννητον μαθόντες ὅπως μὲν αὐτὸν εἶναι προσήκει νοεῖν ἐδιδάχθημεν, ὅ, τι δὲ ἐστὶ διὰ τῆς φωνῆς οὐκ ἠκούσαμεν. τὴν οὖν τοιαύτην διαφορὰν ἐπὶ τῆς ἀγίας τριάδος λέγοντες, ὡς τὸ μὲν αἴτιον τὸ δὲ ἐξ αἰτίου εἶναι πιστεύειν, οὐκέτ' ἂν ἐν τῷ κοινῷ τῆς φύσεως τὸν τῶν ὑποστάσεων λόγον συντήκειν αἰτιαθεῖμεν.

Ἐπειδὴ τοίνυν τὰς μὲν ὑποστάσεις ἐπὶ τῆς ἀγίας τριάδος ὁ τοῦ αἰτίου διακρίνει λόγος, τὸ μὲν ἀναίτιως εἶναι τὸ δὲ ἐκ τοῦ αἰτίου πρεσβεύων, ἢ δὲ θεία φύσις ἀπαράλλακτός τε καὶ ἀδιαίρετος διὰ πάσης ἐννοίας καταλαμβάνεται, διὰ τοῦτο κυρίως μία θεότης καὶ εἷς θεὸς καὶ τὰ ἄλλα πάντα τῶν θεοπρεπῶν ὀνομάτων μοναδικῶς ἐξαγγέλλεται.

give the same definition of “cause” and of “nature”), but we indicate the difference in manner of existence. For when we say that one is “caused,” and that the other is “without cause,” we do not divide the nature by the word “cause,” but only indicate the fact that the Son does not exist without generation, nor the Father by generation.

But we must need in the first place to believe that something exists, and then scrutinize the manner of existence of the object of our belief. Thus the question of existence is one, and that of the mode of existence is another. To say that anything exists without generation sets forth the mode of its existence, but what exists is not indicated by this phrase. If one were to ask a husbandman about a tree, whether it were planted or had grown of itself, and he were to answer either that the tree had not been planted or that it was the result of planting, would he by that answer declare the nature of the tree? Surely not. But while saying how it exists he would leave the question of its nature obscure and unexplained. So, in the other case, when we learn that He is unbegotten, we are taught in what mode He exists, and how it is fit that we should conceive Him as existing, but what He is we do not hear in that phrase. When, therefore, we acknowledge such a distinction in the case of the Holy Trinity, as to believe that one is the cause, and another is of the cause, we can no longer be accused of confounding the definition of the *hypostases* by the commonness of nature.

Thus, since on the one hand the idea of cause differentiates the *hypostases* of the Holy Trinity, declaring that one exists without a cause, and another is from the cause; and since on the one hand the divine nature is apprehended by every conception as unchangeable and undivided, for these reasons we properly declare the divinity to be one, and God to be one, and employ in the singular all of the other God-befitting names.